

LECTURE 4

Compactness: Heine–Borel and Bolzano–Weierstrass

MATH S4061 | Introduction to Modern Analysis I

Thursday, 4 June 2026

Mathematics is the science of the infinite.

HERMANN WEYL

CONTENTS OF THIS LECTURE

- 4.1 Compactness, Closedness, and Boundedness
 - 4.2 The Finite-Intersection Property and Nested Sets
 - 4.3 Heine–Borel and Bolzano–Weierstrass
 - 4.4 Interior, Closure, and Connectedness
-

Overview. Lecture 3 defined compactness—every open cover has a finite subcover (3.4.1)—and showed it is intrinsic (3.4.4). Here we draw out its consequences: a compact set is closed and bounded, a closed subset of a compact set is compact, and nested nonempty compact sets meet. Specialising to $\mathbb{R}^k$ through nested intervals and k -cells yields the two pillars of the subject—*Heine–Borel* (in $\mathbb{R}^k$, compact = closed and bounded) and *Bolzano–Weierstrass* (every bounded infinite set has a cluster point). A short topological coda—interior, closure, connectedness—closes the chapter.

4.1 Compactness, Closedness, and Boundedness

Theorem 4.1.1

A compact set is closed and bounded

A compact subset K of a metric space (X, d) is closed and bounded (4.3.4).¹

Proof 4.1.1

Direct Proof that the Complement Is Open.

- (1) If $K = \emptyset$ it is closed and bounded vacuously, so assume $K \neq \emptyset$. Fix $p \notin K$. For each $q \in K$ set $r_q = \frac{1}{2}d(p, q) > 0$; the triangle inequality makes $B_{r_q}(p) \cap B_{r_q}(q) = \emptyset$.
- (2) The balls $\{B_{r_q}(q)\}_{q \in K}$ cover K , so by compactness finitely many do: $K \subseteq B_{r_{q_1}}(q_1) \cup \cdots \cup B_{r_{q_n}}(q_n)$.
- (3) Put $r = \min(r_{q_1}, \dots, r_{q_n}) > 0$. Then $B_r(p)$ is disjoint from every $B_{r_{q_i}}(q_i)$, hence from K . So p is interior to K^c ; as $p \notin K$ was arbitrary, K^c is open and K is closed. ■

[Direct] ball separation; cf. R 2.34.

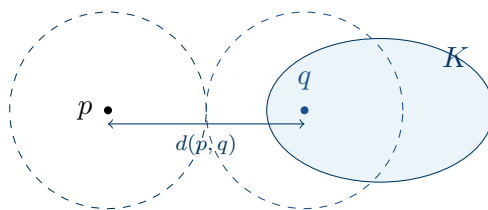


Figure 4.1.2. SEPARATING A POINT FROM A COMPACT SET. For $p \notin K$ and $q \in K$, the balls of radius $r_q = \frac{1}{2}d(p, q)$ about p and q are disjoint; as q ranges over K they cover it, and a finite subcover walls p off — so K^c is open (proof of 4.1.1).

Proposition 4.1.3

A closed subset of a compact set is compact

If K is compact and $F \subseteq K$ is closed in K , then F is compact.

Proof 4.1.3

Direct Proof that a Closed Subset of a Compact Set Is Compact.

- (1) Let $\{V_\alpha\}$ be an open cover of F . Since F is closed, F^c is open in K , and $\{V_\alpha\} \cup \{F^c\}$ is an open cover of K .
- (2) By compactness, finitely many cover K : $K \subseteq V_{\alpha_1} \cup \cdots \cup V_{\alpha_n} \cup F^c$.
- (3) Since $F \cap F^c = \emptyset$, dropping F^c still covers F : $F \subseteq V_{\alpha_1} \cup \cdots \cup V_{\alpha_n}$. So every open

¹Bounded: fix any p ; the balls $B_n(p)$ ($n \geq 1$) cover K , so finitely many do, and $K \subseteq B_N(p)$ for the largest N .

cover of F has a finite subcover, and F is compact. ■

[Direct] cf. R 2.35.

4.2 The Finite-Intersection Property and Nested Sets

Proposition 4.2.1

The finite-intersection property

Let $\{K_\alpha\}$ be a family of nonempty compact subsets of X such that every finite subfamily has nonempty intersection. Then $\bigcap_\alpha K_\alpha \neq \emptyset$.²

Proof 4.2.1

Proof by Contradiction of the Finite-Intersection Property.

- (1) Suppose $\bigcap_\alpha K_\alpha = \emptyset$ and fix one K_1 . Then $K_1 \cap \bigcap_{\alpha \neq 1} K_\alpha = \emptyset$, i.e. $K_1 \subseteq (\bigcap_{\alpha \neq 1} K_\alpha)^c = \bigcup_{\alpha \neq 1} K_\alpha^c$.
- (2) Each K_α is compact, hence closed (4.1.1), so each K_α^c is open: $\{K_\alpha^c\}_{\alpha \neq 1}$ is an open cover of K_1 .
- (3) By compactness of K_1 , finitely many cover it: $K_1 \subseteq K_{\alpha_1}^c \cup \cdots \cup K_{\alpha_n}^c$, i.e. $K_1 \cap K_{\alpha_1} \cap \cdots \cap K_{\alpha_n} = \emptyset$ — a finite subfamily with empty intersection, contradicting the hypothesis. ■

[A9] uses 4.1.1; cf. R 2.36.

Corollary 4.2.2

Nested nonempty compact sets meet

A nested sequence $K_1 \supseteq K_2 \supseteq \cdots$ of nonempty compact sets has $\bigcap_n K_n \neq \emptyset$.³ This is the countable nested compact corollary to Rudin's finite-intersection theorem (R 2.36).

Proposition 4.2.3

Nested closed intervals in $\mathbb{R}$

A nested sequence of nonempty closed intervals $I_n = [a_n, b_n]$ ($I_{n+1} \subseteq I_n$) has $\bigcap_n I_n = [\sup_n a_n, \inf_n b_n] \neq \emptyset$.

²Read this as the open-cover definition turned inside out. Complementing the K_α trades “no finite subfamily covers” for “no finite subfamily has empty intersection,” so a family of compact sets in which every finite batch meets cannot have empty total intersection. The moral to keep: with compactness, sharing every *finite* subfamily is enough to force one common point—nothing can leak away to infinity.

³A descending chain of nonempty compact sets cannot shrink away to nothing. This is the shape of almost every existence proof that follows: trap your target inside nested compact sets whose diameters tend to 0, and the single point they all share is the object you were chasing—the move behind k -cells being compact (4.3.1) and behind finding limits of sequences. Compactness is exactly what stops the chain from closing on the empty set.

Proof 4.2.3

Proof by a Supremum Argument that Nested Closed Intervals Meet.

- (1) Nesting gives $a_1 \leq a_2 \leq \cdots \leq b_2 \leq b_1$, so every b_m is an upper bound for $\{a_n\}$. By the least-upper-bound property (1.6.1), $\alpha = \sup_n a_n$ exists and $a_n \leq \alpha \leq b_n$ for all n ; thus $\alpha \in \bigcap_n I_n$.
- (2) Moreover $x \in \bigcap_n I_n \iff a_n \leq x \leq b_n \forall n \iff \sup_n a_n \leq x \leq \inf_n b_n$, so $\bigcap_n I_n = [\sup_n a_n, \inf_n b_n]$.

[A5] uses 1.6.1; cf. R 2.38.

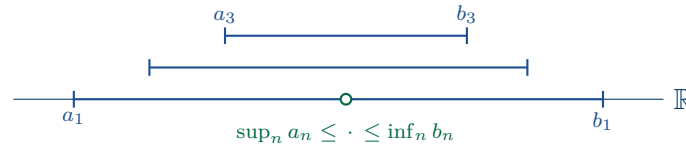


Figure 4.2.4. NESTED CLOSED INTERVALS. A descending chain $[a_1, b_1] \supseteq [a_2, b_2] \supseteq \cdots$ shares every point of $[\sup_n a_n, \inf_n b_n]$ — in particular it is never empty (4.2.3).

Definition 4.2.5

k-cell

A *k*-cell (R 2.17) is a product of closed intervals

$$I = [a_1, b_1] \times [a_2, b_2] \times \cdots \times [a_k, b_k] \subseteq \mathbb{R}^k.$$

Proposition 4.2.6

Nested *k*-cells meet

A nested sequence of nonempty *k*-cells $I_1 \supseteq I_2 \supseteq \cdots$ has $\bigcap_n I_n \neq \emptyset$.

Proof 4.2.6

Proof Coordinatewise that Nested k-Cells Meet.

- (1) Write $I_n = [a_1^{(n)}, b_1^{(n)}] \times \cdots \times [a_k^{(n)}, b_k^{(n)}]$. For each fixed coordinate i the intervals $[a_i^{(n)}, b_i^{(n)}]$ are nested, so by 4.2.3 some $\alpha_i \in \bigcap_n [a_i^{(n)}, b_i^{(n)}]$.
- (2) Then $\alpha = (\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_k) \in \bigcap_n I_n$.

[A5] applies 4.2.3 in each coordinate; cf. R 2.39.

4.3 Heine–Borel and Bolzano–Weierstrass

Theorem 4.3.1

Every *k*-cell is compact

Every k -cell $I \subseteq \mathbb{R}^k$ is compact.⁴

Proof 4.3.1

Proof by Repeated Bisection that the k -cell Is Compact.

- (1) Let $\delta = (\sum_{i=1}^k (b_i - a_i)^2)^{1/2}$, so $d(x, y) \leq \delta$ for all $x, y \in I$. Suppose I is *not* compact: some open cover $\{G_\alpha\}$ has no finite subcover.
- (2) Bisecting each edge at its midpoint splits I into 2^k sub-cells. If each had a finite subcover, so would I ; hence some sub-cell I_1 has none. Iterating gives nested cells $I \supseteq I_1 \supseteq I_2 \supseteq \cdots$, each without a finite subcover, with $\text{diam } I_n \leq 2^{-n}\delta$ (each bisection halves every edge, hence the diagonal).
- (3) By 4.2.6 some $x \in \bigcap_n I_n$. As $\{G_\alpha\}$ covers I , $x \in G_{\alpha_0}$ for some α_0 , and G_{α_0} open gives $r > 0$ with $B_r(x) \subseteq G_{\alpha_0}$. Choose N with $2^{-N}\delta < r$ (Archimedean, 1.7.1); then $I_N \subseteq B_r(x) \subseteq G_{\alpha_0}$ — so I_N is covered by the single G_{α_0} , contradicting that it has no finite subcover. ■

[A7] bisection and nested cells (4.2.6); cf. R 2.40.

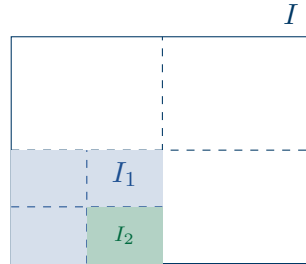


Figure 4.3.2. BISECTING A k -CELL. A k -cell without a finite subcover has a 2^k -bisection inheriting the defect; iterating gives nested cells $I \supset I_1 \supset I_2$ of diameter $\rightarrow 0$, trapping a point that a single cover element must contain (proof of 4.3.1).

Theorem 4.3.3

Bolzano–Weierstrass

Every infinite subset E of a compact metric space⁵ K has a cluster point in K .

Proof 4.3.3

Proof by Contradiction that E Would Be Finite.

⁴Why is a solid box compact when an open or unbounded set is not? Bisect it into 2^k smaller boxes: if no finite part of a cover handled the whole box, some sub-box inherits the same defect, and repeating traps a single point whose own little neighbourhood—sitting inside *one* set of the cover—then swallows an entire tiny box, the contradiction. The trap works because halving sends the diameter to 0 across finitely many coordinates; that is just what breaks down in infinitely many dimensions, and why Heine–Borel (4.3.5) is a fact about $\mathbb{R}^k$ and not metric spaces at large.

⁵Rudin reserves the name *Bolzano–Weierstrass* (R 2.42) for the bounded- $\mathbb{R}^k$ case; the general compact statement here is R 2.37, whence the $\mathbb{R}^k$ case follows by enclosing a bounded set in a k -cell (4.3.1).

- (1) Suppose no point of K is a cluster point of E . Then each $q \in K$ has $r_q > 0$ with $B_{r_q}(q) \cap E \subseteq \{q\}$.
- (2) The balls $\{B_{r_q}(q)\}_{q \in K}$ cover K ; by compactness finitely many do. Each holds at most one point of E , so E is finite — contradicting that E is infinite.

■

[A9] cf. R 2.37.

Definition 4.3.4**Bounded set**

$E \subseteq X$ is *bounded* (R 2.18) if $E \subseteq B_r(p)$ for some $p \in X$ and $r > 0$.

Theorem 4.3.5**Heine–Borel**

For $E \subseteq \mathbb{R}^k$ the following are equivalent:⁶

1. E is closed and bounded;
2. E is compact;
3. every infinite subset of E has a cluster point in E .

Proof 4.3.5

Proof of the Heine–Borel Theorem by Cycling (a) $\Rightarrow$ (b) $\Rightarrow$ (c) $\Rightarrow$ (a).

- (1) (a) $\Rightarrow$ (b). Bounded E lies in some k -cell I ; I is compact (4.3.1) and $E \subseteq I$ is closed, so E is compact (4.1.3).
- (2) (b) $\Rightarrow$ (c). This is Bolzano–Weierstrass (4.3.3).
- (3) (c) $\Rightarrow$ (a), contrapositive. If E is *not closed*, a cluster point $q \notin E$ exists; choose $p_n \in E$ with $\|p_n - q\| < \frac{1}{n}$. The set $\{p_n\}$ is infinite (a finite range would repeat some value $p \in E$ infinitely, forcing $q = p \in E$), and its only possible cluster point is $q \notin E$: any $y \in E$ has $\|p_n - y\| \geq \|q - y\| - \frac{1}{n} \geq \frac{1}{2}\|q - y\|$ eventually. If E is *not bounded*, choose $p_n \in E$ with $\|p_n\| > n$; then $\{p_n\}$ is infinite (the norms are unbounded) with no cluster point, since any $B_1(y)$ holds only finitely many p_n . Either way (c) fails.

■

[A9+A4] uses 4.1.3, 4.3.1, 4.3.3; cf. R 2.41.

4.4 Interior, Closure, and Connectedness

Definition 4.4.1**Interior and closure**

⁶The equivalence (a) $\iff$ (b) is *special to $\mathbb{R}^k$* : in a general metric space a compact set is closed and bounded (4.1.1), but closed-and-bounded need not be compact.

For $E \subseteq X$, the *interior* $\overset{\circ}{E}$ is the set of interior points of E (2.3.3); it is open, and E is open iff $E = \overset{\circ}{E}$. The *closure* (R 2.27) is

$$\overline{E} = E \cup \{\text{cluster points of } E\} \quad (3.2.1);$$

it is closed — indeed the smallest closed set containing E .⁷

Definition 4.4.2

Connected and disconnected

A metric space (X, d) is *connected* (R 2.45) if its only subsets that are both open and closed (“clopen”) are $\emptyset$ and X . Equivalently, X is *disconnected* when $X = A \cup B$ for nonempty, disjoint, open sets A, B .⁸

⁷If $C \supseteq E$ is closed then C contains every cluster point of E , so $C \supseteq \overline{E}$; and $\overline{E}$ is itself closed, so it is the least such set.

⁸The picture is just “one piece.” A clopen set other than $\emptyset$ or X would split X into two parts, each open, with neither approaching the other—a clean break. Requiring the only clopen sets to be $\emptyset$ and X says precisely that no such split exists, so the space hangs together in a single piece.

Index of Objects

4.1.1	Theorem: A compact set is closed and bounded	2
4.1.3	Proposition: A closed subset of a compact set is compact	2
4.2.1	Proposition: The finite-intersection property	3
4.2.2	Corollary: Nested nonempty compact sets meet	3
4.2.3	Proposition: Nested closed intervals in $\mathbb{R}$	3
4.2.5	Definition: k -cell	4
4.2.6	Proposition: Nested k -cells meet	4
4.3.1	Theorem: Every k -cell is compact	4
4.3.3	Theorem: Bolzano–Weierstrass	5
4.3.4	Definition: Bounded set	6
4.3.5	Theorem: Heine–Borel	6
4.4.1	Definition: Interior and closure	6
4.4.2	Definition: Connected and disconnected	7